

KATHA STUDIO

Temple of Ten Shadows

An archaeologist finds a relic that wakes Hampi's stone dancers — and a smuggling chain that wants history silent, portable, and priced.

Book 04 · Adventure · Hampi

Lead: Priya Rao · 22 pages



Original Indian graphic book · For personal reading

Temple of Ten Shadows · Book 04

Page 1 of 22



Moon through a broken vimana. The pillars have been waiting for a listener.

Boulders look like a conversation the earth started and never finished. Priya's camp is a stove, a permit, and a stubbornness her professors called unprofessional and her bones call correct.

NARRATOR

“Hampi does not ruin. It rehearses.”

ECHO



By lantern she copies a frieze the way other people copy phone numbers.

A small shadow sits beside the notebook like a cat made of dusk. It does not take the pencil. It is, for now, polite.

PRIYA

“If I miss a wrist-angle, I miss a century’s joke.”

SCRATCH



The gold box is not hidden so much as postponed.

Ten carved dancers peel off stone like wet ink. Their ankles remember drums. Their faces remember audiences who brought oranges and arguments.

PRIYA

“Easy. I am not here to steal the sentence. I am here to finish reading it.”

SHHNK



They do not attack. They audit.

Priya's boots are not dance shoes. She bows anyway, badly, which the shadows find charming because honesty photographs well in moonlight.

SHADOW DANCER

“Keeper or taker? We have a test. It involves feet.”

HUM



A flashlight cuts the corridor — battery-powered entitlement.

He has a buyer in a city that likes old things the way it likes quiet servants. He has a gun he does not know how to make historically accurate.

SMUGGLER

“Relics belong to whoever can carry them out.”

CLICK



Priya fights with provenance, which is slower than a bullet and harder to dodge.

She does not, in fact, want him to ask. She has seen a collector's apartment where the curtains danced without wind until the man learned to return a bronze lamp.

PRIYA

“Carry it out and the shadows follow you home. Ask me how I know.”

GRIND



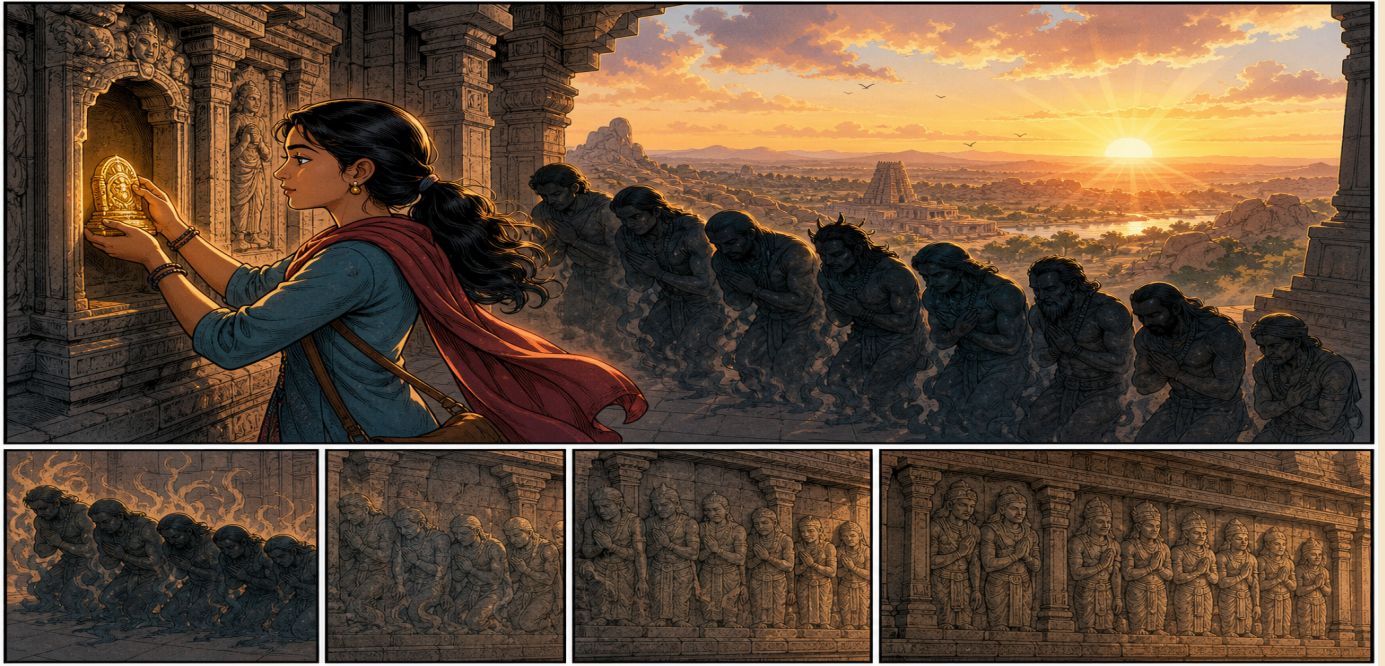
The shadows freeze mid-reach, insulted by the beam.

She lowers her torch to the floor. The smuggler's flashlight looks suddenly lonely. In the half-dark, the dancers look like law.

PRIYA

“Light is not the enemy. Greed is just badly aimed light.”

FLICKER



He grabs the box. His shadow lengthens in a way shadows should not.

The box contains a contract: whoever owns it hosts the rehearsal. Ten performances a night. No intermission. No applause that is not earned.

SMUGGLER

“It is light. Why is it heavy in my sleep already?”

CLACK



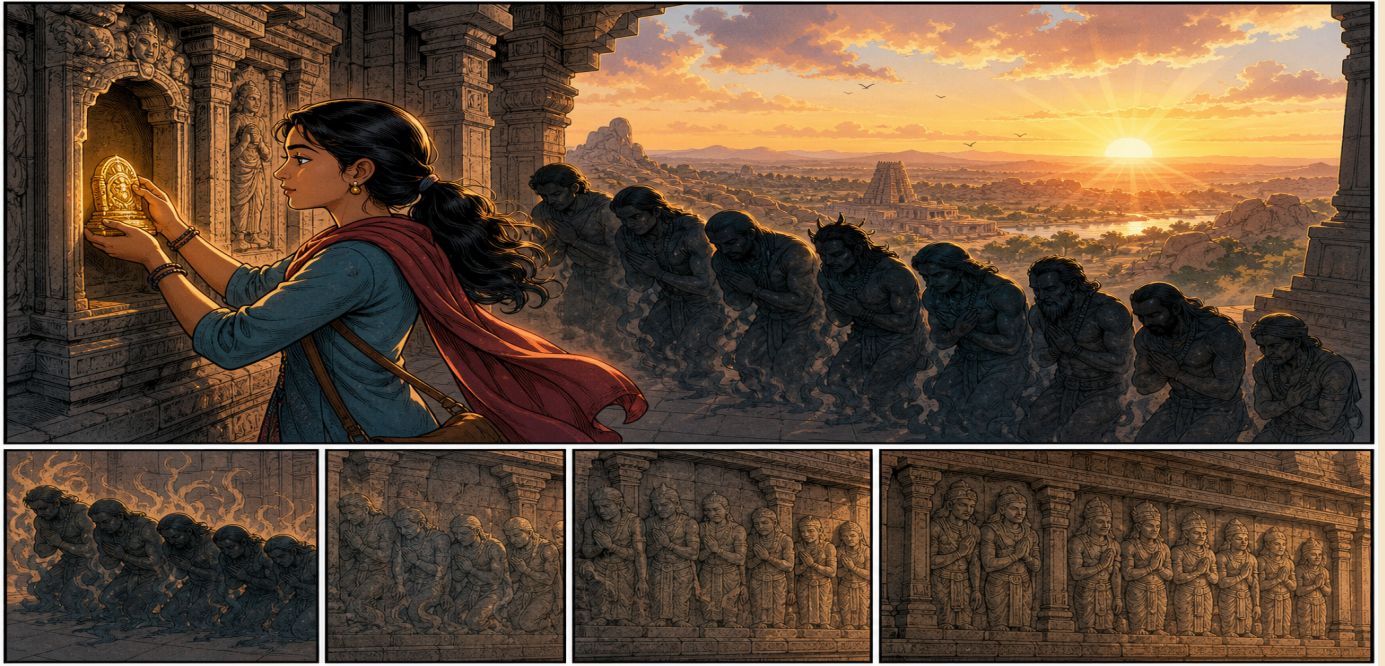
Priya offers a trade: the box stays, his name leaves the site report's criminal appendix if he walks.

Pride almost ruins him. Then one dancer copies his walk so accurately he sees himself as a thief and is embarrassed in a way no court can schedule.

PRIYA

“I prefer my villains tired, not legendary.”

STEP



The box returns to its niche. Ten shadows bow and become carving.

Priya's permit, in this moment, feels like a love letter the ASI did not mean to write. She photographs the niche, not the gold. Gold photographs like a lie.

SHADOW DANCER

"Keepers may look. Takers must dance until their feet remember stone."

HUM



Sunrise. She writes a report the museum will only half believe.

She includes measurements, maps, and one sentence in a footnote: THE SITE IS OCCUPIED. Her editor will try to delete it. The sentence will crawl back.

PRIYA

“Good. Belief is optional. Respect is not.”

BIRDSONG



A week later, tourists come with the kind of quiet that is actually phones on silent.

Priya watches a child bow to a dancer by accident, tripping. The stone seems pleased. She does not put this in the brochure. Brochures are cowards too.

GUIDE

“Do not touch the pillars. They have opinions.”

SHUTTER



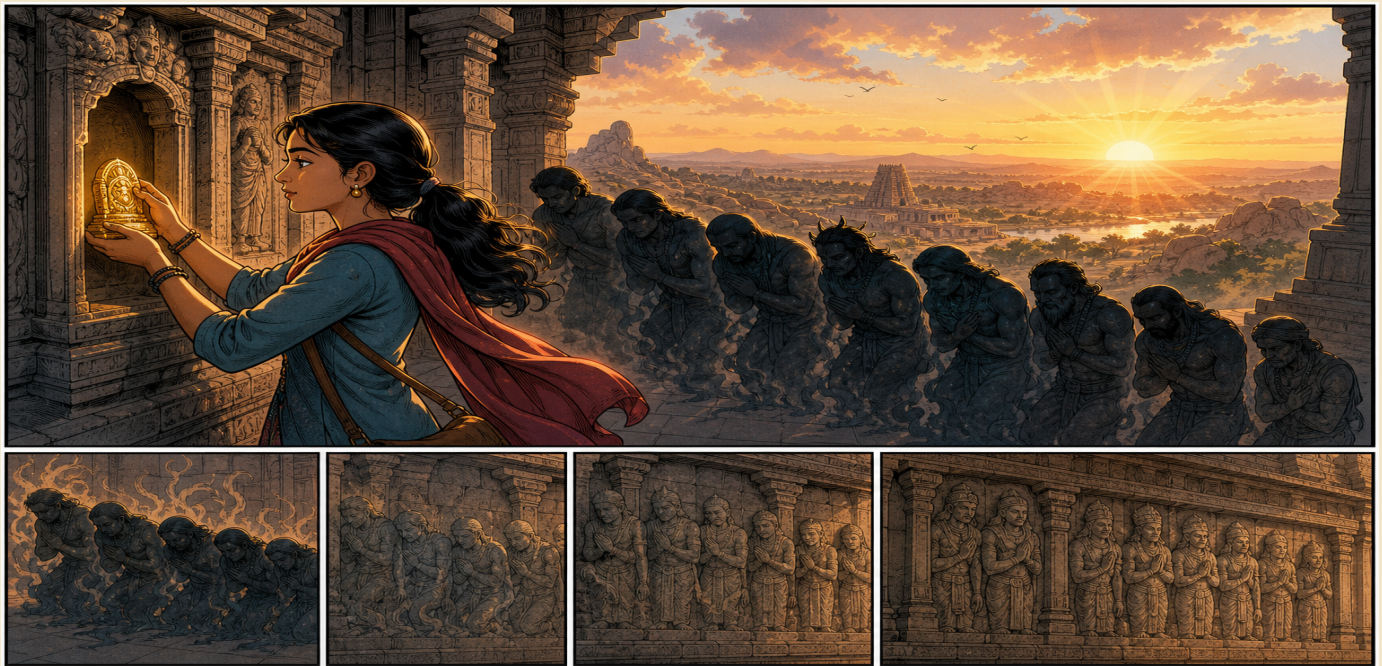
The smuggler's buyer arrives in linen, smiling like a brochure.

Priya names a number: zero, plus the cost of his flight home, plus a lecture she will not let him skip. He calls her emotional. The shadows call him off-key.

BUYER

“Name a number. History is a market.”

CHIME



Night two of the test he did not know he signed.

He returns, sweating linen, and funds a conservation fence instead. Priya accepts the fence and not the apology, which is still in first draft.

BUYER

“Make them stop dancing in the minibar.”

THUD



She teaches a field school how to look without taking.

Students complain, then produce the best drawings of their lives. One of them will become a problem in twenty years. Priya writes his name down anyway, hoping to be wrong.

PRIYA

“Your pencil is a guest. Your ego is luggage. Leave the luggage on the bus.”

SCRATCH



A storm. Lightning makes the temple look briefly brand new.

Priya sits in the mandapa and lets rain argue with dust. The small dusk-cat shadow returns and sits on her permit, which is the highest blessing available.

NARRATOR

“Stone likes to remember its opening night.”

CRACK



She dreams of ten dancers rehearsing a harvest that no longer uses those exact grains.

Waking, she adds a chapter to her notes titled CONTINUITY. It will annoy people who like history in glass.

DANCER

“Keep the steps even if the crop changed.”

SOFT DRUM



Police want a simpler story: heroine, villain, box.

Priya says it is a responsibility with gold around it. They write TREASURE anyway. She initials the form like someone signing a truce with language.

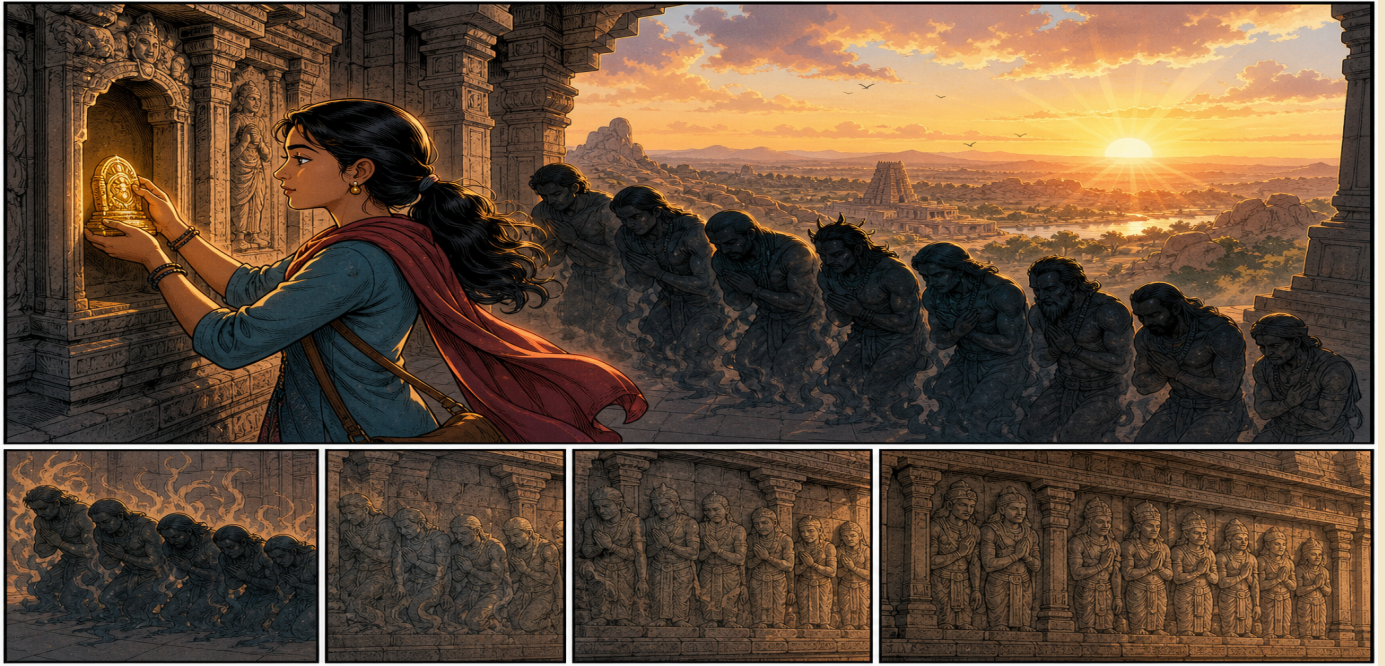
OFFICER

“Just tell us if it is treasure.”

RADIO

Temple of Ten Shadows · Book 04

Page 19 of 22



On leaving day the niche looks ordinary, which is how the best secrets dress.

The boulders do not wave. Waving is for people. Still, a hawk turns once over the vimana in a way that feels like correspondence.

PRIYA

“I will come back when the moon is rude again.”

PACK



In Bengaluru a committee asks why her photos contain extra darkness.

Priya smiles the smile of someone who has met worse committees than this, including one made of stone. She says cropping is how empires begin.

CHAIR

“We can crop the shadows.”

PROJECTOR



She keeps a torch battery labelled HAMPI, as if light had a hometown.

It is a joke and a vow. Archaeologists collect both.

PRIYA

“If I forget my manners, drain yourself.”

CLICK



Moonrise again, somewhere, on stone that is practising being eternal.

The ten shadows sleep in their carving. The box stays unpriced. And a woman on a night bus south of the boulders sleeps with dust still in her hair, which is how you can tell the work was real.

NARRATOR

“Priya Rao, reader of unfinished sentences.”

OWL